

Amazon Internship Interview Experience

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About the company

Amazon.com, Inc. is an American multinational technology company that focuses on e-commerce, cloud computing, digital streaming, and artificial intelligence. Some of its famous products/services include Alexa, Kindle, Amazon Web Services, Prime Video, etc.

Role details

Offered role: SDE intern (Software Development Engineer)

Tenure: 2 months

Candidate Profile

The candidate's profile is the first thing that an interviewer sees and thus, sets the topic of discussion for the interview. So, building a strong resume is of utmost importance. Do not hesitate to mention any kind of achievement/award you have received be it technical/non-technical. Give a crisp but detailed description of the projects you have worked on and internships (if any) and be honest about your work/contributions.

During the intern season, you will hear a lot about having a one-page resume and how advantageous it is. I would say that as long as you have good points to put on your resume, you need not worry about how long it is. But try your best to keep it crisp and do not add unnecessary information.

Preparation Strategy

The time taken by a person to achieve the same level of coding proficiency as another varies a lot. Thus, the first step would be to assess yourself and see where you stand. Generally, 2 to 3 months of consistent coding would be sufficient but if you think you would need more time to become confident, please give yourself more time.

Along with data structure and algorithms, interviewers might also pose questions on subjects like OS, DBMS, etc. So, it is advised to have an overview of some of the important concepts in these subjects like fragmentation, critical section problem, ACID properties, etc. When focusing on coding, it is important to learn why we are using certain functions as questions based on important concepts like OOPs can be asked. Time complexity is one of the most important things that is looked at in an interview so be thorough with it.

Another taboo that I would like to address is that companies prefer students who can code in C++/C and coding in languages like python would not be suitable. I attended the online test and interviews of about 6 companies and I coded in python in all of them. What the companies look

for is if you are able to communicate with them and understand the question and come up with an optimized solution within the given time. The language you use is not important as long as you are able to write optimized code for any question.

Some useful books/youtube channels that you could refer to include:

- Cracking the coding interview (Book)
- Grokking algorithms (Book)
- Striver (Youtube Channel)
- CodeBasics (Youtube Channel)
- Jacob Sorber (Youtube Channel)
- Apna College (Youtube Channel)
- William Lin (Youtube Channel - mainly for students interested in competitive programming)

Preliminary Round

The preliminary round was an online round that was conducted on amazon's own coding platform. 2 coding questions were asked in this round and 1.5 hours were given to solve them. I don't remember the exact questions but one of them was a variant of binary search and the other was a DP problem. The questions were fairly easy and I had solved similar questions in the past so I was able to finish the test in 15 minutes and it passed all test cases.

Note that you need to come up with an efficient solution as fast as possible to get shortlisted as somebody who was able to solve the same in an hour may not get selected because of the time they took as most companies have a set limit to the number of people they can qualify to the next round.

After the coding test, we were asked to take a work-style assessment which took about 15 minutes to finish.

Technical Round(s)

Around 300 students attended the online test and out of that only 75 students got selected for the next round. They scheduled one 45-minute coding interview for all of us.

My interview started off with a bunch of questions based on my resume. One of the questions was to name the most interesting project I have worked on till now and why I found it interesting. If you are posed with a similar question, I would suggest you talk about the project where you learned the most and be honest about the difficulties you faced and how you overcame them. Use any opportunity to highlight your strengths when such questions are posed.

After this, the first question was presented to me. The question was to detect a cycle in a linked list. This is a very common question so I was able to solve it in around 10 minutes and I was asked a bunch of questions on how it would work against edge cases and the time and space complexity.

Once the interviewer was convinced, he posed the next question which was to explore all possible paths in a binary search tree and find and print the path at which the sum of the node values is maximum. For this question, I was asked to come up with my edge cases to test the code. I used DFS to solve the question. A follow-up question was asked where I was also asked to print the level at which the maximum sum is encountered but I had run out of time before I could finish coding it out fully.

The interview ended with me asking a couple of questions about the interviewer's area of work and his experience working at amazon.

Result

The waiting period was grueling and terrifying as the internship season is very hard on your mental health. If an interview doesn't work out, you would not have much time to get over it as the interview for the next company would be days away. I got my result exactly a week after my interview and I was over cloud nine (and still am 😊) when I got to know that I got the internship.

Tips

Here are some things that I wish somebody told me before I went through this entire process:

- Go through internship experience blogs

On the day before your interview, read the internship experience blogs of people who attended interviews at that company. If you are lucky, you might even get the same questions. But either way, you would be able to understand what they look for in a candidate and how you are expected to tackle situations.

- Have a good connection with your seniors

Seniors will be your best friends during this season as they would have faced very similar things in the past. Have a good rapport with them and ask all your questions (dumb or not) to them and be very clear about the decision you take.

- Manage your time well

In an interview, you are only given 45 to 60 minutes to impress a stranger that you have the skills to work in their company. In the given time, around 10 to 15 minutes would be taken up in giving the general introduction. Try to prepare a standard answer to the "Tell me about yourself" question that covers all your strengths. Thus, try to keep the discussion short and crisp and give yourself more time to code and showcase your coding skills.

- Understand the hiring process at CUIC

CUIC is the placement/intern cell of Anna University. To ensure all students get placed, they have certain rules in place. One such is that if you get an internship at a company, you will not be allowed to attend the tests for the companies coming henceforth. So you either have to accept the offer or leave the hiring process. If you reject the offer, you will not be allowed to attend the tests of other companies. The solution is to have a good mix of good companies and safe bets that you attend the test of.

- It is okay to feel bad

It sucks to face rejections especially when you thought you would get it. Understand that it is okay and sometimes even luck plays a role in the selection and you might be left off. When you get rejected, you have to pull your morale up somehow and analyze what you think went wrong. It is completely okay to rant but do not let it derail you from the process.

Please reach out to me via my phone number if you have any doubts: +91 9789002028.

I hope this was useful and wish you all the best for your interviews!